

Ἀνάξαρχος ὁ Ἀβδηρίτης

Anaxarchus of Abdera on Kingship and Wisdom

eul_aid: fhs

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Ἀττική](#) [Attic \(phi, frg\)](#)
Domain: [Φιλοσοφία](#) [Philosophy](#)
Format: [Συναγωγή](#) [Collection](#)
Affiliation: [Democritean](#)

Anaxarchus was a Greek philosopher from Abdera who lived and taught in the late 4th century BCE. He was a follower of the atomist tradition founded by Democritus. He is historically significant for his close association with Alexander the Great, whom he accompanied as a court philosopher and advisor during the Asian campaigns.

Ancient accounts describe him as advocating for emotional tranquility and contentment, earning him the nickname "the Happy" or "the Blissful One." A famous story illustrates his philosophical stance: when Alexander was severely wounded, Anaxarchus consoled him by referencing the goddess of Necessity, suggesting that even kings must accept natural forces. His life ended violently after Alexander's death. According to tradition, he was executed by a tyrant on Cyprus, and he reportedly met his death with defiant composure, asserting a separation between his true self and his physical body.

No writings by Anaxarchus survive intact. He is credited with a work *On Kingship*, likely addressed to Alexander, but his ideas are known only through reports by later ancient authors. According to modern scholars, his primary importance lies in his role as a philosophical bridge. His skeptical views about the reliability of the senses are considered a direct influence on Pyrrho of Elis, who also traveled with Alexander. This connection makes Anaxarchus a key figure linking earlier Democritean atomism to the later development of Greek Skepticism.

Works (2)

- [Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [On Kingship and Wisdom](#) · 3 passages
- [Μαρτυρίαι](#) · [Testimonies](#) · 16 passages

Other Democritean Authors

- [Ναυσιφάνης ὁ Τήσιος](#) · [Nausiphanes of Teos](#) · 2 works